

The Focus

Three sample tools as your staff receive them, one of them in Spanish, and the guide that turns them into practice

You name the one thing your staff needs to get better at. We build to it and nothing else — a practical, one-page tool delivered to every adult in the building, every three weeks, all year. The guides in this packet turn those tools into something that happens in a classroom.

Everything in this packet is a real sample, not a mockup of one.

EVERY

Three weeks

About thirteen tools across the school year.

BUILT TO

One pain point

The one the district names. Not a catalog.

PREP REQUIRED

None

No slides to make, no facilitator to train.

WHERE THE TOOLS AND THE SESSIONS MEET



Tools arrive in staff inboxes every three weeks and get read alone. The ninety-minute session is where two or three of them turn into a plan with a student's name on it.

WHAT'S IN THIS PACKET

Tool 1	Give them seven seconds — Wait time. What a para finds in their inbox on a Tuesday.
Tool 2	Hand them the first three words — Sentence starters on a sticky note. Sent three weeks later.
Tool 3	Four words before the lesson — Pre-teaching the vocabulary buried in the directions.
In Spanish	Dele siete segundos — Tool 1 for a para who would rather learn in their first language.
The guide	Running the ninety minutes — Groups of ten or fewer. Roles, agenda, adaptation questions, reflection sheet.

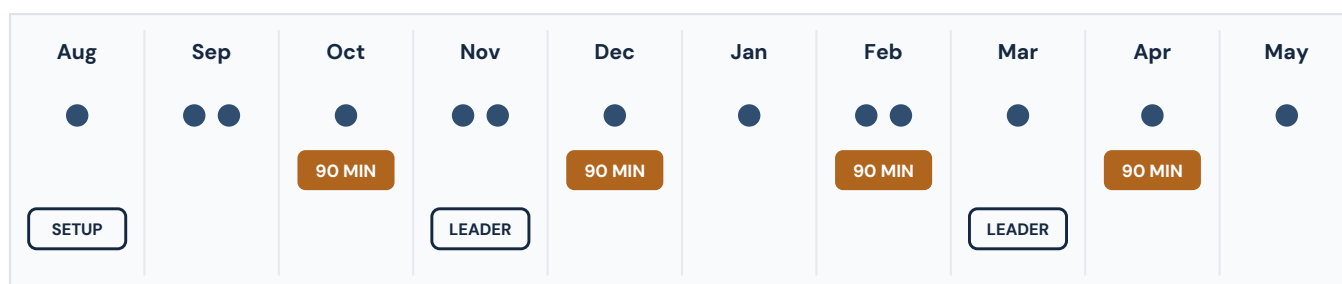
What a year looks like

An illustrative year, not anyone's actual calendar. Yours gets built around your own institute days.

A tool every three weeks, all year. A ninety-minute session every few months where two or three of those tools become plans with students' names on them. Two leadership check-ins to look at what the data is saying and decide where to point the next stretch.

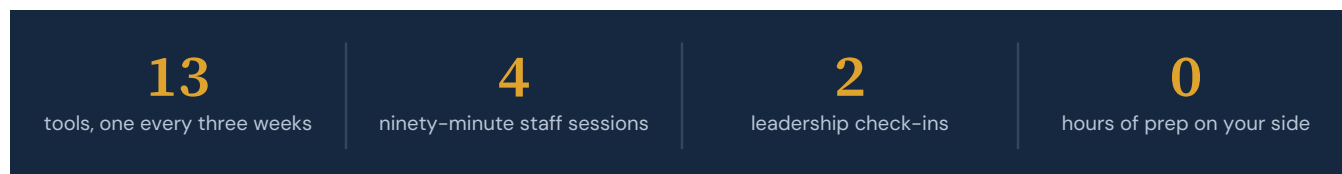
Contracts run August to July or January to December. Two months are treated as summer and turned off, on your calendar rather than ours.

AN EXAMPLE SCHOOL YEAR



● A tool lands in every inbox 90 MIN The ninety-minute session □ Leadership check-in, or setup in August

WHAT THAT ADDS UP TO



The cadence is the point. Staff stop asking whether another one is coming, and the session on the calendar is what turns a tool that got read into a change that got tried.

How the dates get set

- Onboarding is one form. No kickoff call, no implementation phase.
- Delivery starts the Tuesday after you send it back.
- Both leadership check-ins get booked during onboarding, so they are on the calendar before the year starts.

If your calendar shifts

- Sessions attach to your institute and PD days, not to ours.
- Move one and the three-week tool cadence keeps running underneath it.
- The next session simply has one more tool to choose from.

One topic. One group.

A building is one way to draw the line. A role across the district is the other

A building picks one topic and every adult receives tools on it — teachers, paras, coaches, specialists, front office. That is the design, not a pricing convenience. When the para and the teacher in the same room read the same tool the same week, they start using the same words with the same student. The building ends up with one vocabulary instead of six versions of an idea.

The other way to draw it is by role. Every ESL para in the district, or every one-to-one para, wherever they work. Same rate, same year of tools, built for the job instead of the building.

ONE TOPIC

Per group

Chosen from your data, not from a catalog.

WHO RECEIVES IT

Your call

Every adult in a building, or one role district-wide.

WHAT YOU GET

Shared language

Across a building, or across a role.

TOPICS DISTRICTS CHOOSE

De-escalation

Before it escalates, and after

Classroom management

Routines, pacing, transitions

Supporting multilingual learners

The sample topic in this packet

Para and teacher partnership

Two adults, one room

Working with diverse student groups

Across cultures and abilities

Student engagement

Getting past compliance

Family communication

Hard conversations, first contacts

New staff support

The first year, and the first month

Executive function

Organization, planning, follow-through

Attendance and belonging

Why students show up

Behavior support plans

Writing them, and running them

Small group instruction

Grouping, pacing, pulling back

Why a whole building

- A student hears the same phrasing from the teacher, the para, and the coach.
- Nobody is the only person in the room who was trained on it.
- The ninety-minute session works because the people in it actually work together.

Why a single role

- Most paras are the only person doing their job in their building.
- The tools are written for that job rather than for everyone at once.
- A role is a role at any size, so twelve people and sixty cost the same.

What a district gets

The features that show up in every engagement, regardless of the topic you choose.

- **A tool every three weeks**
Roughly thirteen a year, every one of them built to the single pain point the district names. Two months off for summer, on your calendar, not ours.
- **Two levels inside every tool**
A starting version for a first-year para and a harder version for someone who has done the basic move for twenty years. Same tool, same page.
- **One tap, not a survey**
In my plans this week. Skipping this one. I want help with this. That is the entire ask, and it is what shapes what we send next.
- **In the email and on paper**
The tool renders in the message body, with a one-page printable underneath for the staff who will not read on a phone.
- **Spanish on request**
Any tool can ship in a second language for the staff who want it.
- **Two leadership sessions a year**
Virtual. Review the KPIs, name the hurdles that came up, and decide what the next stretch of tools should target.

What never changes

The topic is yours. Everything below is ours, and it is the same in every building we work with.

- **The same four questions, everywhere**
Every group in every building works the same four adaptation questions. A K-2 building and a high school are having a comparable conversation.
- **The same reflection sheet**
One format across the district, so what comes back can actually be read side by side.
- **The same build standard for every tool**
One page, numbered steps rather than paragraphs, black-and-white copier safe, legible at phone width, and a link back to the Hub. No exceptions, no filler tools.
- **The same cadence**
Every three weeks, on a Tuesday, without exception during the school year. Nobody has to wonder whether one is coming.
- **The same reporting**
Response rates and the themes staff asked for help with, on your dashboard, in the same shape every cycle.

SENT

A new tool every three weeks

Tuesday, September 22, 2026

Tool 1 of 13

Sept 22

Oct 13

Nov 3

Give them seven seconds

Works in any grade, any subject

When a multilingual student goes quiet after a question, the silence feels much longer to you than it does to them. Most adults rescue at about two seconds. Seven seconds gets you more English than the rescue ever will.

Nothing to prep. Use it in your next block.

TRY IT THIS WEEK

- 1 Ask the question, then count to seven in your head. Do not fill the silence with a hint, a rephrase, or an encouraging noise.
- 2 If there is nothing at seven, **repeat the question exactly as you asked it** — same words, same order. A student who is still assembling the sentence loses their place when the wording changes.
- 3 Count to seven again.
- 4 Still nothing? Offer a choice instead of the answer.
“Is it the first one or the second one?”
- 5 When they answer, say their answer back once as a full correct sentence, then move on. No correction lecture — the model is the correction.

New to this

Pick one student and one block this week. Counting to seven while a room is moving around you is harder than it sounds, and it is easier to learn the feel of it in one quiet corner.

Been doing this for years

Stop counting and start tracking. For one week, note which students still need the second seven seconds. That list is a sharper contribution to a services conversation than any screener score.

Watch for: students who answer quickly in their home language and then stop. They have the thinking. The seven seconds is buying them the English, not the idea.

If it doesn't work: some students need to see the question, not hear it again. Write it down and slide it over.

In the email, one tap tells us how this landed:

Your next Focus tool arrives Tuesday, October 13.

Tools like this live in the TDI Learning Hub, where your team can work through them together.

You're getting this because your district partners with Teachers Deserve It. Every three weeks, one tool, nothing else.

SENT

A new tool every three weeks

Tuesday, October 13, 2026

Tool 2 of 13


 Sept 22

Oct 13

Nov 3

Hand them the first three words

One sticky note per student

A student who won't speak in class usually knows the answer. What they don't have is the opening. Give them the first few words of the sentence and they will finish it themselves — out loud, in English, without you speaking for them.

Two minutes of prep. Reuse the same note all week.

TRY IT THIS WEEK

- 1 Before the block, write three sentence starters on one sticky note. Match them to what the teacher will actually ask today.
"I think ___ because ___" · "It changed when ___" · "This one is different because ___"
- 2 Put the note on the student's desk. Not in your hand, not in their folder — in front of them, where they can look without asking.
- 3 When the question comes, point at the note and say nothing. Give them the seven seconds.
- 4 If they use a starter, leave it up for the rest of the week. Repetition is what moves it from the note into their head.
- 5 Retire a starter once they've used it twice without looking down. Replace it with a harder one.

New to this

Start with one starter, not three. "I think ___ because ___" carries most discussion questions in most subjects, and one note you actually use beats three you keep forgetting.

Been doing this for years

Hand the pen over. Ask the student to write the next starter based on what they think the teacher will ask. When they can predict the sentence the room wants, they have stopped needing the note.

Watch for: starters that are too long. If it takes more than four or five words to begin, you've written a script, and the student will read it instead of thinking.

If it doesn't work: the starter may not match what the teacher is actually asking. Ask for the discussion questions the day before and rewrite the note to fit them.

In the email, one tap tells us how this landed:

Your next Focus tool arrives Tuesday, November 3.

Tools like this live in the TDI Learning Hub, where your team can work through them together.

You're getting this because your district partners with Teachers Deserve It. Every three weeks, one tool, nothing else.

SENT

A new tool every three weeks

Tuesday, November 3, 2026

Tool 3 of 13


 Sept 22

Oct 13

Nov 3

Four words before the lesson

Five minutes, front-loaded

What stops a multilingual student mid-task usually isn't the concept. It's four words in the directions — compare, sort, estimate, justify. Front-load those four and the student spends the block on the math instead of on the instructions.

Two minutes with the materials. Five minutes with the student.

TRY IT THIS WEEK

- 1 Ask the teacher for the lesson materials the day before, or first thing that morning. Two minutes is enough.
- 2 Read **only the directions** and not the content. Circle every word a new English speaker would trip on. It's almost always the verbs.
- 3 Pick the four that would actually stop the student. Not the ten that could.
- 4 Five minutes before the lesson, show those four words. Say each one, give one plain example, have the student say it back to you.
"Estimate. Close, not exact. About how many? Your turn."
- 5 During the lesson, when the word comes up, point at your list. Don't re-teach it — the pointing is the whole intervention.

New to this

Skip the day-before ask this week. Circle four words in whatever lands in front of you that morning. Getting the habit is worth more right now than getting the perfect four words.

Been doing this for years

Keep a running list of every verb you circle. After a month you have the ten words that block your students most, and that list belongs in front of the teachers you support.

Watch for: content words you assume everyone knows. "Bar graph," "number line," and "difference" are vocabulary, not background knowledge.

If it doesn't work: you may have picked words the student already had. Ask them to explain one back to you before you spend the five minutes.

In the email, one tap tells us how this landed:

Your next Focus tool arrives Tuesday, November 24.

Tools like this live in the TDI Learning Hub, where your team can work through them together.

You're getting this because your district partners with Teachers Deserve It. Every three weeks, one tool, nothing else.

ENVIADO

Una herramienta nueva cada tres semanas

martes, 22 de septiembre de 2026

Herramienta 1 de 13

22 sept.

13 oct.

3 nov.

Dele siete segundos

Sirve en cualquier grado y materia

Cuando un estudiante multilingüe se queda callado después de una pregunta, el silencio le parece mucho más largo a usted que a él. La mayoría de los adultos interviene a los dos segundos. Siete segundos le van a dar más inglés del que le da el rescate.

No requiere preparación. Úselo en su próximo bloque.

PRUÉBELO ESTA SEMANA

- 1 Haga la pregunta y cuente hasta siete en su mente. No llene el silencio con pistas, ni reformule, ni haga sonidos de ánimo.
- 2 Si a los siete segundos no hay nada, **repita la pregunta exactamente como la hizo**: las mismas palabras, en el mismo orden. El estudiante que todavía está armando la oración pierde el hilo cuando usted cambia las palabras.
- 3 Cuente hasta siete otra vez.
- 4 ¿Todavía nada? Ofrezca una opción, no la respuesta.
“¿Es la primera o la segunda?”
- 5 Cuando responda, repita su respuesta una vez como oración completa y correcta, y siga adelante. Sin sermón de corrección: el modelo es la corrección.

Si apenas empieza

Escoja un solo estudiante y un solo bloque esta semana. Contar hasta siete mientras el salón se mueve a su alrededor es más difícil de lo que parece, y se aprende mejor en un rincón tranquilo.

Si ya lleva años haciéndolo

Deje de contar y empiece a registrar. Durante una semana, anote qué estudiantes todavía necesitan los segundos siete segundos. Esa lista aporta más que cualquier examen de nivel.

Fíjese en: los estudiantes que responden rápido en su idioma y luego se detienen. El pensamiento ya lo tienen. Los siete segundos son para el inglés, no para la idea.

Si no funciona: algunos estudiantes necesitan ver la pregunta, no volver a escucharla. Escríbala y pásesela.

En el correo, un solo toque nos dice cómo le fue:

La voy a usar esta semana

Esta vez la dejo pasar

Quiero ayuda con esto

Su próxima herramienta Focus llega el martes 13 de octubre.

Herramientas como esta viven en el TDI Learning Hub, donde su equipo puede trabajarlas en conjunto.

Recibe esto porque su distrito trabaja con Teachers Deserve It. Una herramienta cada tres semanas, nada más.

90 minutes with your paras

Turning the last few Focus tools into a plan your staff will actually use

USE THIS GUIDE IF YOUR PARAS FIT IN ONE GROUP OF TEN OR FEWER

Your paras have received two or three Focus tools since you last met. This is the ninety minutes where they stop reading them alone and start adapting them for the students in front of them. Hand pages one and two to whoever is in the room.

This runs on professional learning time with students out of the building, so nobody is being pulled off an assignment. The ninety minutes is the ninety minutes.

GROUP SIZE

Ten or fewer

Above ten, people stop talking. Split into two groups instead.

YOU'LL NEED

Printed tools

The last 2–3 Focus PDFs, one set per person.

RUNS FOR

90 minutes

A 45-minute version is on page four.

BEFORE THE SESSION — ABOUT FIFTEEN MINUTES OF YOUR TIME

- 1 Find them a place to work together.** Chairs in a circle, door closed, everyone able to hear each other.
- 2 Print one set of tools per person.** Not per group. Paras mark up their own copy and take it with them.
- 3 Assign the roles before anyone walks in.** Five roles, listed on page three. In a group of ten, two people share the Scribe job.

TEN IS THE CEILING



Eleven and up, the quiet people stop talking and the last block runs out of time. Split into two groups instead.



Chairs in a circle

WHERE THIS SITS IN THE CYCLE



Tool



Tool



Tool

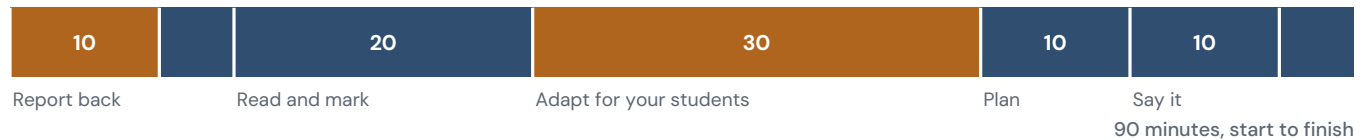


Your 90 minutes

Tools arrive in your paras' inboxes every three weeks. They read them alone. This session is where those tools turn into something that happens in a classroom.

The ninety minutes

Sized for a group of ten. The two gold blocks are the ones that carry the session.



0:00

10 min

What happened last time

Around the group: did the plan you wrote last session actually happen? One sentence each, no defense required. Skip it at the first session. After that it is the most important ten minutes on this page.

0:10

5 min

Pick the two

Spread out the last two or three tools and pick the two you will work on. Let the group choose. A tool someone already tried is a fine pick — they have something to report.

0:15

20 min

Read and mark

The Reader reads one tool aloud, then everyone reads it again on their own copy. Each person marks one step they would change and one they think works as written.

0:35

30 min

Make it fit your students

The four adaptation questions. In a group this size, take them in pairs for the first fifteen minutes, then come back together — otherwise the same two voices answer all four.

1:05

10 min

Build the plan

Every para names one student, one block, one day next week. Not one plan per group — one per person. The Scribes write them on the reflection sheet.

1:15

10 min

One sentence each

Every person says their own plan out loud. Ten people, one sentence apiece. Saying it in front of peers is the accountability.

1:25

5 min

Reflect and turn in

Finish the reflection sheet and hand it in before leaving the room. Homework does not come back.

Who does what

Assign these before the session. Rotate every session except the Reality-checker, which works better when someone grows into it.

Timekeeper	Calls each transition out loud from the agenda. Without this the group spends fifty minutes on the first tool and writes the plan in the hallway.
Reader	Reads each tool aloud once before anyone discusses it. This matters for paras who process better by ear and for anyone reading in a second language.
Scribe	Fills in the reflection sheet as the group talks, not at the end. In a group of ten, two people share this so no one is writing for the whole ninety minutes.
Reality-checker	Names the student this would not work for. Their job is to disagree, which means nobody else has to be the person who is not being positive.
Reporter	Keeps the last block moving so all ten people get their sentence in. Not a summary of the discussion — just what each person is going to do.

How to group them, and where

- **No more than ten in a group.**
Break your paras into groups of ten or fewer and give each group a place to work together. Ten is the ceiling, not the target — above that, people stop talking and the last block runs out of time.
- **Group by who they serve, not by seniority.**
Put the paras who support the same kind of student together — same grade band, or ESL together, or one-on-one supports together. The adaptation questions only work if the group is picturing similar students.
- **Spread the veterans across groups, on purpose.**
Each tool has a starting version and a level-up version. That split only pays off if every group has someone who has already done the basic move for years.
- **Keep the groups the same all year.**
The report-back at 0:00 only works with people who heard your plan last time. Rotate the roles instead of the rosters.
- **Find each group a real space.**
Classrooms, the library, a conference room — anywhere they can pull chairs into a circle and hear each other. Two groups in one large room means the louder one sets the pace.

Say this to start

“You have all gotten a couple of these tools in your email. Nobody is checking whether you read them.

Today we are figuring out which parts would actually survive in your room and which parts would not. You know that. I do not.

You leave with one thing you are trying next week.”

Three ways this goes sideways

- It turns into venting. Fifteen minutes is healthy. The Timekeeper points back at the tool after that.
- Two people do all the talking. In a group this size, work the adaptation questions in pairs first, then come back together.
- The plans stay vague. “Use more wait time” is not a plan. “Seven seconds with Marcus, Tuesday reading block” is.

The adaptation questions

Read these aloud at 0:35. They are the same four questions in every building and every session, so people get faster at them.

- 1 Which of your students would this work for tomorrow, with no changes at all?
- 2 Which student would it fail for, and what is the one thing that would have to change?
- 3 What does this look like in your setting — a small group, a push-in block, a bus line, a lunch table?
- 4 What would you need from a teacher or from your administrator to make it work?

Reflection sheet

One per group. Every para's own plan goes on it by name. Turn it in before you leave the room.

THE FOCUS · SESSION REFLECTION	Date _____	Building _____	Room _____
Tools we worked on: _____ One line per person: name, student or group, block, and day _____ _____ _____ _____ _____ What we changed about the tool, and why _____ What we need from our administrator _____ _____ Scribe _____ Turned in to _____ Keep a copy for your TDI check-in call			

Four things that make it stick

- Open the next session with the report-back. Knowing they will be asked is what makes the plan real.
- Answer the “what we need” line in writing for at least one group before the next tool arrives.
- Have everyone tap their response in the Focus email before leaving — it lands on your dashboard.
- Pair people up. One text to a partner mid-cycle, nothing formal.

If you only have 45 minutes

- Cut to one tool, not two.
- Five to report back, ten to read, fifteen on the adaptation questions, ten to build the plan, five to reflect.
- Drop the group share. Keep the reflection sheet and the report-back — those are the accountability.